



feature

51 million

The number of jobs that could be lost in 2009 according to UN predictions.

professional networkers is that other members provide accurate information about themselves. As you would on your resume, present yourself well, be concise and decide what you want to reveal. Stick to relevant experience. Other people on the network want to know more about you apart from just the professional brass, so highlight some of your prominent interests. These may help you and others to find common ground to connect. However, don't overdo it.

Be sure to have as complete a profile as possible. If you try to network with people with an incomplete profile it looks like you're only interested in finding people but won't bother to include enough information about yourself to indicate how a connection with you might be mutually useful. Take a few moments to fill in the gaps. If you wish to include a photo on your profile, it goes without saying, that you keep it professional.

On LinkedIn, be sure to edit the public profile link. This will give you a unique url such as <http://www.linkedin.com/in/yourname>. It's easy to remember and is picked up by search engines. Speaking of searches, you should include relevant key words and phrases that define your interests and the purpose of networking. These catch words will make sure you are thrown up regularly in searches.

Next comes the actual networking. There are several ways to go about this. The first thing any networking web site will do is import contacts from your email service. However, these are people you know quite well, and so defeats the purpose of networking. You are supposed to network to meet new people.

From the point of view of active job seeking, there are two approaches you can take. There are third-party recruiters and in-house HR personnel of companies active on professional networks. It is important to connect with them. The other approach is to connect with people of the same grade within a company you aspire to join. Getting familiar with would-be colleagues means that you might get referred for an opening. You can also join one of the many industry specific groups on the web site such as a group on private equity, or public relations. People within a group are quite willing to network with each other. Suppose you develop J2ME apps on the side. You can find several groups and really hit upon something big in a collaborative project, perhaps. Your groups can also indicate to people what you are there for. If you come from a reputed school, join its alumni, maybe go ahead and create a group if you can't find one you're looking for.

While going about networking with people, remember it's not a contest to see how many contacts you can make. The quality of your network is as important as its size. Contacts from irrelevant indus-

tries or areas where you have no interest or knowledge, aren't of much value. So be picky about whom you connect with. LinkedIn will impede you from growing your network indiscriminately. Its policy is strictly against spamming and displaying connections as trophies. In fact, the exact number of connections for any user will not be shown beyond 500. One of the first things you should do is protect the people in your network by making your contacts list non-public.

There is also a system of introductions that LinkedIn follows. If there is someone in your network whom you wish to connect with, but this person is two degrees away from you, you can use the trusted contacts in between for an introduction. Another interesting outcome of LinkedIn's guarded outlook is the emergence of a band of people who call themselves LinkedIn LIONS, or LinkedIn's Open Networkers. These people are rather open to networking and will typically have keywords such as InvitesWelcome, LION and Open Networker in their profile. Search for these keywords and send an invite to connect to these people. Don't forget to add relevant details in the message you send to them, such as your interests.

What about Facebook and Orkut?

According to recent reports, there has been a significant growth in the number of people above the age of 30 who use Facebook. In fact, iStrategylabs.com reports that over the last six months the 35-54 year old demographic segment not only continued to grow the fastest, but it accelerated to a 276.4 per cent growth rate. Naturally, these are people who have careers on their minds rather than college. So a fair bit of professional networking does happen on social networks such as Facebook or Orkut. As with professional networks, you can find a fair number of industry specific groups and communities there too. Recalling an incident, an active networker said, "I had ran out of LinkedIn invites and wanted to recruit some people for my venture. After screening some profiles and narrowing in on a candidate, I went to Orkut and tracked him down. I then spoke to some common contacts, arranged a meeting and nabbed some good talent". Taking a cue, we must realise that not only can social networks be used as alternative means to connect, but also to run background checks.

The line between strictly social networks and business networks is fast blurring. Some argue that using social networks for connecting to people professionally, has its own advantages. They say you get to know people as a whole. This brings up a whole new can of worms about privacy, and what you want your prospective employers, employees, and colleagues to see. Young professionals who are using Facebook for professional networking need to be aware of the

The art of connecting

Visit as many groups as possible that spark your interest

After all finding common ground is the key to expanding your network.

Be clear about your purpose and goals of networking

You should be able to articulate what you are looking for and how others may help you. Too often people will genuinely ask you, "How may I help you?". In such situations, you shouldn't be left groping in the dark for a response.

Forward referrals quickly

Remember you are a valuable link in the chain when it comes to being a part of a professional network. Be active with any reference requests you get and if you can't fulfil them, reply stating your reason.

Create a meaningful profile

Your online profile is your virtual business card. Make sure it represents you well. Use apps and recommendations to enhance your profile.

Be concise and make your intentions clear

People on LinkedIn or any other networking web site have very little patience for beating about the bush. If you are connecting with someone with a job opportunity in mind, say so. If you're looking at a network for no immediate purpose, make that clear as well. Same goes if you're seeking investments for your venture.

Gratitude and courtesy go a long way

Much like in the real world, a heart-felt thank you, or an offer to reciprocate a favour will do you good.

Avoid default text

Whenever approaching new people, remember to customise the template message. Nothing more annoying than reading "Hi, I wish to add you to my network - XXX".

amount and type of information they are sharing. Limit your photos and keep a close eye on which photo you're tagged in. You'll find yourself choosing friends wisely, making friend groups and controlling exactly what each group gets to see.

For those of you holding on to a job, surely there is more to social networking. Remember that there is a whole breed of networking web sites out there that helps millions of users conduct far more contextually important activities such as scout for business opportunities, connect with recruiters, and find the people and knowledge they need to achieve their goals. In fact, in the context of the on-going recession, there couldn't be a better time for you to be active in this realm and invest in building your network and social capital. You never know when someone might be looking for you and how someone you know can help you connect. ■

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